EU likely to avoid gas rationing this winter

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【メール原文】

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EU likely to avoid winter gas rationing despite high prices

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Despite missing its November storage target, the EU will likely avoid winter gas rationing, with 75% odds that supplies will suffice despite prices of €70–€100 per megawatt-hour (MWh) in December and January.

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A renewed US-Iran war escalation (now 30% odds, down from 60%) and a severe cold spell could force rationing in several EU countries and push prices above €120 per MWh.

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State-backed incentives, LNG imports, and lower demand should avert shortages, but very low spring storage levels will make refilling difficult in 2027.

The EU will pay heavily for gas this winter, but it is unlikely to have to ration it. It is likely (75% odds) that state-backed incentives, access to Atlantic LNG, and price-driven demand cuts carry the EU through March, with gas on the Dutch Title Transfer Facility (TTF), Europe's benchmark gas price, likely to trade at €70–€100 per MWh in December and January, in line with Eurasia Group's earlier forecast that prices would stay above €65 per MWh (see: European gas prices will stay elevated through winter , 22 September 2026). Key signposts include the status of the Strait of Hormuz, winter weather, and the level of competition or cooperation among EU capitals.

Although Germany missed its 70% storage target for 1 November (sites were 61% full), supply is likely sufficient barring an exceptionally long and cold winter. Instead of filling up ahead of winter (as Italy, the EU's second-biggest gas consumer, has done), Germany is relying on special tenders that pay traders to keep gas available for February and March 2027. Most of Germany's LNG comes from the US, where destination-flexible cargoes go to the highest bidder and will continue to command high prices.

Many laden LNG tankers are currently headed for Europe, carrying around 10 million metric tons of cargo (equivalent to about 9% of the EU's total LNG imports in 2025). In effect, storage has moved from onshore sites to ships at sea. If the situation in the Middle East does not escalate further, these arrivals could trigger a sharp price drop within weeks.

EU governments will face higher gas prices after failing to meet the bloc-wide storage target of 80%. At their 29 October meeting, EU energy ministers debated voluntary demand cuts, a lower storage target (for next year), and joint LNG purchasing, but adopted no specific measures. High prices and energy-efficiency measures continue to hold down usage, with EU gas demand about 17% lower than before the 2022 crisis.

A US-Iran escalation or a severe winter would intensify internal competition for LNG cargoes. An escalation in the Middle East would be the first potential trigger, but Eurasia Group no longer sees this as the most likely scenario. The US is likely to maintain its standoff of blockades and sanctions through the end of 2026 (60% odds), with escalation at 30% and a limited deal to reopen the Strait of Hormuz at 10% (see: The political window for escalation has closed , 9 November 2026). Even so, the standoff continues to constrain Gulf supply. Iran is hitting one or two ships a day, which will likely reduce shipping capacity in early 2027 and could threaten Europe's post-winter refill, keeping gas prices high in spring and summer 2027. If the US were to strike, Iran would retaliate aggressively (see: Iran likely to retaliate aggressively if US attacks , 6 November 2026).

Weather would be another potential trigger. Seasonal outlooks lean toward a cold start to winter but a mild end, though uncertainty is high, especially for early 2027. Persistently subdued Gulf exports through March, combined with a colder-than-average winter, could push European gas prices above €120 per MWh at their peak this winter. Such price spikes could lead to gas curtailment in two or more member states, testing the bloc's solidarity rules, which commit member states to sharing gas during extreme shortages. Some infighting has already commenced, with Italy accusing Berlin of burdening its partners by filling its storage late.

Signposts to watch for gas shortages:

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US-Iran standoff: US strikes on Iranian energy, followed by further Iranian attacks on Ras Laffan or LNG carriers, push toward the shortage case. A deal pushes toward relief.
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Iranian attacks on shipping: A sustained pace of one or two ships a day would squeeze shipping capacity into early 2027 and raise refill risk even without escalation.
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Emergency declarations: A member state declaring a gas emergency under EU security-of-supply rules is the earliest formal marker of the shortage case.
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Winter weather: A prolonged cold spell, Arctic freezes that last for weeks, and low wind output would put enormous pressure on demand.

Filling gas storage to target thresholds will be difficult next year. Without mandatory purchasing, EU storage could end March close to 10% full if the winter is cold, with the Strait of Hormuz likely to remain disrupted under the standoff. Even in a mild winter, storage is likely to be very low by spring. German sites will likely be less than 20% full at the end of March. Brussels may further loosen its 80% filling target if the figure is firmly out of reach. The rules already let countries undershoot that figure, and they expire in 2027; Germany wants them scrapped after that.

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